DOWNTOWN

Sunday
October 4, 2026
THE HINDU

ANNA NAGAR

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No shelter at platform for fast trains in Thiruninravur



B. PRABHU

Commuters waiting for fast trains forced to stand in the morning sun

Passengers using Platform 5 at Thiruninravur railway station are facing inconvenience due to the lack of adequate shelter and seating facilities. Fast trains halt at the platform, and passengers waiting for these services are left standing in the open, exposed to direct morning sunlight.

Regular commuters have urged the railway authorities to provide a proper covered shelter along with adequate seating facilities on Platform 5. Passengers have also requested the authorities to consider extending the existing shelter.

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtown-feedback@ thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number.









‘Sewage contamination in Metro water supply’

T.R. ILAYAKUMAR

Residents of East Balaji Nagar at Kallikuppam in Ambattur find the water supplied by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply & Sewerage Board through its pipes non-potable. The odour and colour point to sewage contamination.

This has been the case for the past two years. Among the worst affected roads are Pillaiyar Kovil Street and Fourth Street.

East Balaji Nagar People Welfare Association has made several complaints to the CMWSSB and also to Greater Chennai Corporation but our efforts have been in vain.

Residents are forced to rely on private water suppliers.

T.R. Ilayakumar is the president, East Balaji Nagar People Welfare Association

Sewage contamination in CMWSSB’s water at East Balaji Nagar at Kallikuppam in Ambattur. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Manikandapuram Main Road in a sorry state’



Manikandapuram Main Road in Thirumullaivoyal. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

D.SURESH

Manikandapuram Main Road in Thirumullaivoyal is in a deplorable state for a year now. The road that was dug up for some civic work has not been restored. It is muddy and uneven. Driving and walking on this stretch is quite difficult.

As the road is in bad shape, autorickshaw and cab drivers are reluctant to enter the road. In some cases, the drivers charge more fare, citing the bad condition of the road.

Another issue is the door-to-door household waste collection vehicles are not regularly visiting the area due to the poor road condition.

This is particularly difficult for houses where residents are away during the day and are unable to hand over the garbage when the street-cleaning team happens to visit. Further, there are no bins on the road.

It may be noted that this road witnesses heavy traffic due to its connection to CTH Road and Cholambedu Road. The prolonged battered state of the road is causing considerable inconvenience to residents.

D.Suresh is a resident of Thirumullaivoyal

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A HOBBY EVOLVES TO MEET GEN ZERS ON THEIR TERMS

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai **P2**



NEVER TOO LATE TO START AFRESH

Chennai resident Seshadri Sukumar kickstarted a career in sports photography, mid-life, turning his back on the familiar and the comfortable and that has made all the difference. Aged 71, he is right now covering the 20th Asian Games in Japan **P4**

Citizens group seeks corrective measures in ongoing SWD work

Difference in road levels; sewage discharge in SWD; and SWD manholes getting hidden under encroachments were among the issues raised by the forum

RAGHUKUMAR CHOODAMANI

Stormwater water drain construction, carried out by the Greater Chennai Corporation, is making steady progress on Perambur High Road - North.

Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum, a citizens forum, which is keeping a close watch of the work, has noticed some issues that can give room for waterlogging.

It requests GCC to correct the difference in road levels at the intersection of Venkat Raman Canal Street and Perambur High Road - North.

Until two decades ago, water used to flow from Venkatraman Canal Street, an interior lane, to Perambur High Road - North, an arterial road. But successive relaying of Perambur High Road - North without proper milling has disrupted the natural drainage gradients.



Perambur High Road - North on September 30, 2026

The forum expects the ongoing stormwater drain work on Perambur High Road to address this issue.

It may be noted that from time to time, Madras Hight Court has directed the government bodies to ensure that the height of the roads does not increase.

And the forum draws attention to an untreated raw sewage overflowing from the incomplete SWD on the stretch of Perambur High Road - North, between Saraswathi Square and Madhavaram High Road. The issue of a missing link of this incomplete SWD was also highlighted.

Attempts to locate the source of illegal sewage discharge exposed the deplorable state of the existing stormwater drain. This shows lack of coordination between the Greater Chennai Corporation and Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply & Sewerage Board.

The forum also highlighted the issue of encroachments and parking of vehicles over stormwater drains.

The manholes of stormwater drains get hidden and this hampers the cleaning and desilting of stormwater drains. GCC reclaimed public spaces on Perambur High Road - North as part of the ongoing work. But those spaces should be protected by providing a proper footpath with bollards or guardrails exclusively for the pedestrians. Attempts to encroach upon this space should be suppressed with an iron hand.

Another issue has to do with avenue trees. Recently, two people got injured when a tree collapsed. Vehicles also got damaged in that incident. The reason is the roots of the tree were disrupted and weakened due to the ongoing stormwater drain work.

These issues have been escalated on the occasion of the visit by the Zonal Office of Zone 6 - Thiru Vi Ka Nagar, Executive Engineer, and Assistant Engineer of Ward 71 on October 1.

Raghukumar Choodamani is the convenor of Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum

‘Unmarked speed breakers in Villivakkam pose a threat’



Red Hills Road in Villivakkam.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

S. VENUGOPAL

There are six speed breakers on Red Hills Road in Villivakkam. But none of them has the mandatory white line markings. And that makes the stretch unsafe, especially during night.

It may be noted this road witnesses heavy traffic as it is one of the approach roads to Villivakkam railway station and market. This has been the status of the road for more than a year. This road falls under Ward 94 of Zone 8 ofGreater Chennai Coporation. Several complaints to Ward 94 officials have gone in vain.

S. Venugopal is a resident of Kolathur

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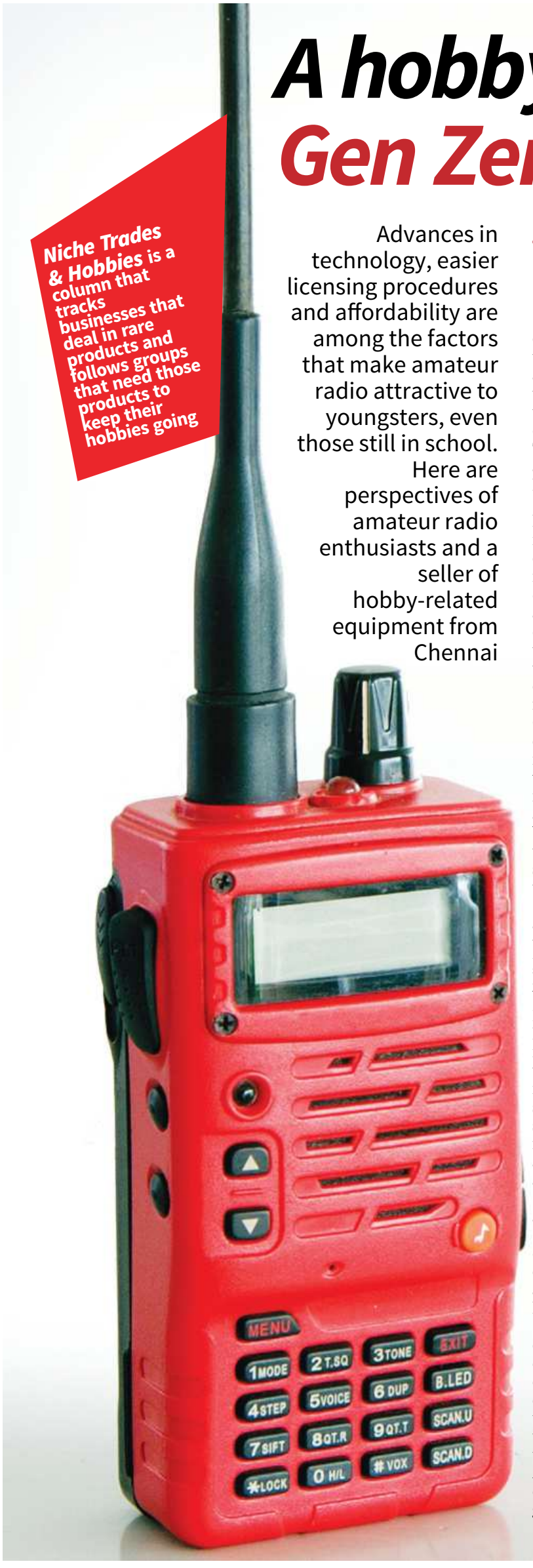
A damaged manhole cover on Poonamallee High Road compromises the safety of pedestrians. The image was taken on October 2, 2026.
PHOTO. RAGU R



Niche Trades & Hobbies is a column that tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going

A hobby evolves to meet Gen Zers on their terms

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There is usually an apocalyptic air to how Ham radio is perceived. The Ham radio enthusiast is readily visualised as trudging into a land overtaken by a massive disaster and where all technology-based communication lines outside the amateur-radio sphere have broken down. The enthusiast has morphed into a saviour, connecting with a fellow hobbyist elsewhere in the "universe" and communicating a local situation, dire and distressing, amidst the static and crackle of radio communication, to reach help to the suffering. This description is indeed fact-aligned. Ham radio enthusiasts do take centre stage during disasters. One witnessed that during the Kerala floods of 2018 and closer home, in the harrowing first week of December 2015 in Chennai. But distress communication is only one of the things riding on amateur radio air waves. Net sessions (as on-air meetups of Ham radio hobbyists are known) are also defined by banter, in fact, more by small talk than SOS calls. And do not be surprised if the banter is punctuated with Gen Z lingo.

N. Deepan (call sign VU2DPN), a key member of Madras Amatuer Radio Society (MARS), points out that the Ham radio hobby has never been as accessible to youngsters as it is now. From licensing to practising the hobby, the procedures of initiation and the operation of the equipment have become ridiculously simple. Having seen 63 summers and getting started on the hobby around four decades ago, Deepan is at a vantage point to talk about the hobby's evolution.

The Wireless Planning and Coordination wing (WPC) is responsible for conducting Amateur Station Operator's Certificate (ASOC) examination and issuing the license.

Deepan underlines the examinations have become simpler as technology has organically taken certain "subjects" off the table. And the removal of this barrier encourages the entry of youngsters. Anyone aged 12 and above can appear for the exam and get the license. "Where it took one or two years to get a license, it takes approximately one month," observes Deepan, noting that objective questions have replaced the earlier pattern of examination.

And the new license holder can hit the ground running, the process of getting started on the hobby also having become facile. EchoLink, Z3 DMR, and Droidstar allow licensed operators to communicate using just a phone with other amateur radio enthusiasts. Once the license is validated, usually within 24 hours, the software can be used. And that obviates the need to invest in ham radio equipment; that can wait. Deepan has seen the ham radio equipment move from valves to transistors, ICs and now Software Defined Radio (SDR). With advancing technology, the equipment has shrunk, and so has their prices. Deepan attributes the fall in prices to the shift from imported equipment to local dealerships (to sell ham radio equipment, a dealer's license is required).

That brings us to someone like Gaurav Srivatsava and his wife Shivangi Gaurav, both ham radio license holders and diehard enthusiasts, and beyond that, owners of Radio Brewery in Iyyapanthangal (radiobrewery.com), which sells amatuer radio equipment. Shivangi largely manages the business while Gaurav continues to work in the IT sector. Their own personal struggles in finding reliable and cost-effective equipment locally had crystallised into this business venture in 2018. Gaurav recalls that besides importing, Ham radio enthusiasts in Chennai were dependent on a couple of dealers in Delhi. The hobbyists would together buy in bulk to keep prices within their comfort range. Among those who encouraged them to start this business was Deepan, one of Gaurav's mentors and supporters.


Malini D

Among factors that augur well for the hobby, Gaurav says, is the portability of the ham radio gear. He recalls the time when valve radios, measuring six by six feet, "appropriated" a room in exchange for the joy of communicating on amateur radio air waves. Fast forward to now, a low-powered ham radio equipment can "fit into a small bread box". Deepan notes that even if one were to route their ham radio communication through an amateur radio satellite, the allied equipment, which includes SDR dongle, dish antenna and up converter or transverter, is easy on the back, being eminently portable. Both Deepan and Gaurav have noticed youngsters taking to the hobby. Gaurav points out his daughter Pari Gaurav (VI2JXB/ KN6GRI, US amateur radio identifier ID), 19 years old now, cleared the WPC examination at age 12. Deepan's daughter, Malini D. (VU3JJT) is also an avid ham radio enthusiast. Even youngsters without any precedent of ham radio engagement in their families are gravitating towards the hobby for the doors of communication it opens in various parts of the world. Deepan notes, "On the Net, all radio ham hobbyists connect and converse as equals."

To sum up, this hobby seems to have been made for Gen Zers (and the ones following them too) for two reasons. It is a generation that derives its strength and purpose from communication, even with those they will never meet in real life, and this hobby is geared to that. And two, this generation thrives on volunteering, and this hobby can provide opportunities for that during extremely harrowing times.

How accessible is your community?



A scene from *Block A For Accessibility*

LIFFY THOMAS

How accessible is your apartment community? That's the central idea of this short film *Block A For Accessibility*, released with a private screening at PVR Satyam Cinemas on September 25. The 20-minute CBFC-certified film by YWTC (Yes, We Too Can!!!) Charitable Trust, in collaboration with Fiserv and United Way Mumbai as the CSR partner, is a story of care, community, and design.

The film revolves around Natarajan, an ageing father, who after starting to use a wheelchair keeps himself isolated from the vibrant life of his apartment complex because he does not want to trouble his son.

A sudden accident at the building's stairs becomes a turning point for the entire community. The film follows the internal realisation of the association secretary and the decisive action of the builder.

Natarajan's character is played by a deaf person, Ravi Kumar. Voice was given by Umapathy, a wheelchair user. Most of the cast and crew are persons with disabilities, including the director. The film has sign language interpretations along with subtitles.

The film addresses a universal civic necessity: accessible housing that accommodates an ageing population and ensures people of all abilities live with independence and dignity.

For a screening of "Block A For Accessibility" at your apartment complex/workplace, write to yeswetoocan@gmail.com

Handrails: a silver jubilee gift



Not many residents at Raheja Regency, a 25-year-old apartment community in MRC Nagar, likely know the two people who were instrumental in getting handrails installed at strategic points in the society recently. Nonagenarian Arjun Krishna and septuagenarian Vasantha Arjun were too modest to talk about this accessibility feature and agreed to give their names after much prodding by this journalist.

One of the earliest residents of this gated community, when the couple were part of the resident association, they got handrails fixed at most of the blocks some 20 years ago. These have been patronised by all, especially the senior citizens. But the community could do with some more, and the couple themselves have experienced the practical difficulty in not having them.

"One of the ladies has even fallen not having a railing to hold on to it," says Vasantha. The couple sponsored the entire cost of installing the handrailings at some new locations as a gift to the community that has been their home for the last 25 years (the couple marked 25 years of staying in the community this June).

Pool lift: for easy swimming

Madhavi Latha Prathigudupu's day is not complete without accessing the swimming pool at her gated community in Arumbakkam. Since 2022, what makes this common amenity accessible for this para-athlete is the pool lift that was incorporated.

The swimming champion cannot do without being in the pool and her late father had to help her get into the waters. She convinced Triumph Apartments, a community with 108 flats where she owns one, to make the pool accessible. "Before installing the pool lift, we had a demonstration done by the manufacturer with the committee members to get their approval," says Madhavi, president of YWTC Charitable Trust.

Today, she goes independently into the pool (she controls the lift pool through a remote) and most importantly has raised the importance of having inclusive amenities at gated communities not just for those with disabilities but even for use by the elderly. There was no ramp when she moved in to the community; the association did not just construct one for access to her block but made the improvisation at other towers as well.



Accessibility standards of the National Building Code insist on a barrier-free built environment and all common facilities accessible to all people. "It's your right, so ask the builder for such accessible features before investing in a flat," she adds.

Sensory park: designed by special parents



In August, the Community Living Association for Parents of Special Citizens (CLAPS) celebrated four years of moving into an inclusively designed campus at Tiruvallur, near Poondi reservoir.

A group of 50 parents of young adults with special needs got together to conceptualise such a model in a 8.5 acre residential campus that comes with a host of universally designed and accessible amenities.

Latha Krishnan and Vaijayanthi Srinivasan, both special parents, say the activity centre, swimming pool, and sensory park are the most popular among the young adults aged 20 and above.

Unlike the apartment communities where they faced many challenges, here everything is customised in keeping with the different needs of the children, a majority are on the spectrum, some with Down's Syndrome and intellectually disability.

The sensory park, for instance, is a hit for those with autism and has equipment with different textures. The activity centre allows them choose programmes as per one's moods and likes. To oversee the children, there are many external professionals, including the warden, supervisor and activity head.



On A Gobal Stage
is a column about residents of Chennai currently in the spotlight at a global event

Never too late to start afresh

R. RAGU

In cricket, one regularly comes across teams that shift to a whole new lane in the second innings, with surprising progress, eclipsing their first-innings performance. And in that process, they bring immense joy and wonder to spectators.

Seshadri Sukumar has pulled off something similar to that.

Here are the details of 71-year-old Seshadri's second innings: a Press Information Bureau-accredited international sports photographer from Chennai and a Canon EOS Ambassador. He now has a reputation for "checking into" major international sporting events. As this article is being written, he is shooting images of sporting excellence at the 20th Asian Games, unfolding at Aichi Prefecture and Nagaya in Japan.



Before zooming in on what he is doing now, a quick run of his first innings: Sukumar had been working in the banking sector, being an official photographer with Indian Overseas Bank (IOB). He always had an intense desire to be a sports photographer, but that remained a desire for a drearily long time.

When retirement from corporate career was looming large, Sukumar took the plunge and started pursuing sports photography full steam ahead.

After Sukumar has been years into sports photography, in 2021, Sukumar's nephew shared a story about his uncle's passion for sports photography, online. Sukumar was 66 years old then and covering the Tokyo Olympic Games. And the story of how someone is flourishing in a career kickstarted mid-life caught the world's imagination.

Sukuamar's portfolio includes multiple Olympic Games, FIFA World Cups (including the most recent edition), ICC World Cups, Grand Slam tournaments, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, NBA events, FINA World Championships, FIDE World Cups and MotoGP, among several other major sporting events.

Among his iconic photographs is one the Rio Olympics, one that captured the contrasting emotions of the winner and the loser; the photograph won his a gold medal from the Photographic Society of America (PSA).

Sukumar's professional photographs have been distributed through international wire services and stock photography libraries, including Alamy, Zuma Press, IMAGO Images, SOPA Images and Reuters Connect.

Sukumar's life and career are a reminder that it is never too late to start afresh.

Chennai resident Seshadri Sukumar kickstarted a career in sports photography, mid-life, turning his back on the familiar and the comfortable and that has made all the difference. Aged 71, he is right now covering the 20th Asian Games in Japan

SESHADRI IN ACTION AND ONE OF THE PICTURES HE HAS CLICKED.

Strengthening academia-industry connection



B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology recently hosted an international industry collaboration and offer letter presentation ceremony with Crescent Global Outreach Mission (CGOM) and ADEEB Group, marking a significant step toward strengthening international industry-academia partnerships and creating global career opportunities for students. Ansari Wahid, Chief Executive Officer, ADEEB Group, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, was the chief guest.

The ceremony focused on strengthening international industry collaboration and enhancing students' exposure to global employment opportunities. Through this association, the institution is creating avenues for students to connect with international organisations, understand global industry expectations, and develop the skills needed to build successful careers beyond national boundaries, a release said.

A key highlight of the programme was the presentation of offer letters to the selected students.

The interactions emphasised the importance of industry-academia collaboration, international exposure, employability enhancement, and global career development in preparing students for the evolving demands of the international workforce, the release added.

Rally on heart health

In observance of World Heart Day, VS Hospitals organised a four-km rally to spread awareness on heart health. On the occasion, the hospital launched its emergency helpline number 044 - 69698000.

According to a press release, former DGP C. Sylendra Babu flagged off the event at VS Hospitals, Tondiarpet, in the presence of Dr. S. Subramanian Chairman and Managing Director, VS Hospitals, Dr. S. Sundar, Medical Director, Muthu Subramanian, Executive Director, and Prassanna Srinivasan, Group COO.

Sylendra Babu, in his address, stressed on the importance of physical activity to be healthy. Close to 300 people took part including healthcare professionals and members of the public.





Alumni association meet

The Annual General Body Meeting of the Dharmamurthi Rao Bahadur Calavala Cunnan Chetty's Hindu College Alumni Association was held recently at Hindu College on CTH Road in Avadi. According to a press release, financial statement and annual report were studied.



Clothes distributed

The Karuna Club of Pon Vidyashram Senior Secondary School, organised a community outreach initiative.

According to a press release, the school students made voluntary contributions including clothes to old-age homes and orphanages.

The initiative was held as part of CBSE's SEWA (Social Empowerment through Work and Action) programme which aims to nurture empathy, compassion, and social responsibility among children.

The school is at Sapthagiri Nagar, Arcot Road, Valasaravakkam.

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An awareness rally to fight mosquito breeding



Dwaraka Doss Goverdhan Doss Vaishnav College organised a dengue awareness programme in collaboration with Greater Chennai Corporation for the student community and the general public recently.

The programme featured a demonstration on mosquito breeding, a human chain to create awareness among students, and an awareness rally from the College to NSK Nagar, Anna Nagaar.

Principal Capt. S. Santhosh Baboo highlighted the concept of "Each One, Teach One" and urged students to take the responsibility of disseminating dengue-prevention messages to their families and the wider community. Sundhar Raj, Superintendent Engineer, threw light on the breeding of dengue mosquitoes and the measures to prevent it. Iniyan, Assistant Commissioner, explained the breeding patterns of mosquitoes and the techniques used to eradicate mosquito breeding sites. U. Sudha, Zonal Health Officer and College secretary Ashok Kumar Mundhra were among those who took part.

Book on Charles Kennet released



The 200th birth anniversary of missionary Charles Egbert Kennet, who made significant contributions to Christian history in the 19th century, was commemorated with a book release at the Tamil Nadu Archives, Kennet Lane, recently.

Organised by the Christian Historical Society, the book authored by V. B. Ganesan was released by writer and Assistant Editor of Tamil Nadu Archives Vennila. The first and second copies were received by Tamilselvan, Editor, and Balachandran, Assistant Editor, Tamil Nadu Archives.

Manna Selvakumar delivered the welcome address, followed by a historical presentation by the author and felicitation address by Vennila. Later, participants took a historical walk through Kennet Lane and St. John the Baptist Church, where Kennet served for 16 years.

Book on Kriya Yoga released



A book titled "The Awakener of Kriya Yoga - This Book is your Weapon; A Biography of Sujatha Murugan" authored by Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar was released recently.

According to a press release, Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar is a student of Sujatha Murugan, a Yoga teacher.

Inspired by her own transformative journey through Yoga, the author felt an inner calling to document the service of her teacher who has touched the lives of many people.

The book celebrates the timeless values of compassion, discipline, humility, and service that form the foundation of Yogic living, adds the press release. It was released by film director, K S Ravikumar in the presence of dental surgeon and orthodontist, Dr Preethi Udhayaraja. The author believes this work became possible only through the blessings and guidance of the legendary Guru, Mahavatar Babaji, known for the revival of the ancient Kriya Yoga.

The author Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar is a resident of Rangarajapuram.

Carnival for children on road safety





Khivraj Group, automotive retail dealers along with Ather Energy hosted a carnival for children in Ambattur Industrial Estate recently. The programme was aimed to spreading awareness about the importance of following road safety rules.

Called Khivraj Ather Kids Carnival, the event was marked by activities like painting, drawing, puzzles, and games, says a press release. On the occasion, the participants took a pledge to follow the safety rules. Around 700 children took part. They were presented with a certificate and gifts, adds the press release.

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